their religious belief started to trouble me. I was upset not just for myself but on behalf of all Sikhs at the R&AW.

From January 1985 onwards, I began sending a note annually to the secretary (R) to convey that I was not available for foreign assignments during that year on account of personal reasons. The real reason behind sending the note was that I did not want my religion to become a factor in my selection or non-selection for a particular post. Throughout that period, and even much after I retired from service, nobody other than the secretaries (R) concerned would be familiar with the real reasons behind two unusual aspects of my career at the Department. First, was my transfer, in November 1983, from two highly sought-after divisions to an analysis division. The second, was my remaining at headquarters for ten years at a stretch, as against the prevailing norm of officers staying only three to four years at headquarters. It was in pursuance of this policy that in the middle of 1985, a very senior Sikh officer who had headed two 'C' classification (based on living conditions) stations earlier and should have been posted to an 'A' station in the normal course, was sent to third 'C' station.

Sometime in mid-1989, I had a one-on-one discussion with Secretary A.K. Verma in his room about the absurdity of that decision. Slightly emotionally, I told him that my family had a genealogical table, going back almost one hundred generations. Out of those, the last eighteen generations have been Sikhs. All of them were born in India and died here. Since approximately ad 1800 even the records of the immersion of ashes of my successive Sikh ancestors are available either at Haridwar, or Kiratpur in Punjab. I had myself seen the entries of the Ganga immersions in the bahi (record of immersions) maintained for our village by the Panditji at Haridwar. I had also seen the signatures of my father and great-grandfather in that bahi, as visitors who had come to immerse the ashes of their loved ones.

Thereafter, looking straight into Verma's eyes, I said, 'How come a person of my background is not to be trusted, whereas a first-generation person of foreign origin is living in 1 Safdarjung Road as the wife of the prime minister of the country? Have you personally